

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Proverbs

Proverbs

Every day, we face many choices. The book of Proverbs helps guide us through life's challenges. It offers wisdom, practical instruction, and guidance for developing strong character.

Proverbs teaches us how to live wisely in many situations. It encourages us to stay calm during a crisis, be patient under pressure, respond gently to opposition, and stand firm against temptation.

Most importantly, Proverbs teaches that true wisdom comes from a right relationship with God.

Setting

Proverbs is a collection of sayings from different times and social settings. Many of these sayings reflect life in the royal court and give advice about how to behave in the presence of a king. Some come from family life and fit a farming setting. Others relate to commerce, trade, and business.

Much of Proverbs is addressed to a young man who is preparing to begin his working life. The book provides wisdom and guidance for the many situations people in ancient Israel faced. At the same time, its teaching remains relevant today and offers valuable guidance for modern people.

Summary

Proverbs is a collection of wise sayings, advice, instruction, and warnings from ancient Israel. The book has two main parts. The first part contains messages from a father to his son (chapters 1–9). Proverbs is a collection of wise sayings, advice, instruction, and warnings from ancient Israel. The book has two main parts. The first part contains messages from a father to his son (chapters 10–31).

These sayings cover many areas of life. Common topics include wealth and poverty, planning, laziness, prostitution, hard work, relationships, pride, and humility. Proverbs teaches practical wisdom for everyday living and encourages people to make wise choices that honor God.

Genre and Style

Wise Sayings

In the Ancient Near East, people gathered wise sayings into collections so others could use them for guidance in making good decisions. In Israel, as in

nearby nations, these collections helped teach young people and guide them in living wisely. Evidence shows that wisdom collections from Babylon and Egypt were used in school instruction.

A proverb is a short saying that expresses wisdom, an observation about life, or practical advice. People accept these sayings because they reflect truths that are generally recognized through experience. In many situations, a well-chosen proverb can help settle a discussion or provide direction for making a decision.

Hebrew Poetry

Proverbs is also a book of poetry. Its short, carefully chosen words communicate a great deal of meaning. The book rewards careful reading and reflection because its sayings often contain deeper insights. Many proverbs teach through word pictures and comparisons. For example, Proverbs warns against laziness by comparing it to things that commonly cause irritation:

- “Like vinegar to the teeth and smoke to the eyes, so is the slacker to those who send him“ (Proverbs 10:26).

One important feature of Hebrew poetry is parallelism, a style in which two or more lines are connected in meaning. Many proverbs use synonymous parallelism, where the second line repeats and strengthens the idea expressed in the first line:

- “Righteous lips are a king’s delight, and he who speaks honestly is beloved“ (16:13).

Other proverbs are antithetical, meaning that the first and second parts are opposites:

- “Every wise woman builds her house, but a foolish one tears it down with her own hands“ (14:1).

Other proverbs make comparisons:

- “Better a little with the fear of the LORD than great treasure with turmoil“ (15:16).

Understanding these features of Hebrew poetry can help us better understand and interpret the proverbs.

Author

Proverbs began with Solomon, who is identified as its source in Proverbs 1:1. Solomon was known for his wisdom (1 Kings 3:5–15). He collected wise sayings and composed many of his own (1 Kings 4:29–32). Later teachers added more material to the book. For example, about 200 years after Solomon, the offi-

cials of King Hezekiah of Judah collected additional proverbs of Solomon and included them in the collection (Proverbs 25:1). Other contributors mentioned in Proverbs include Agur (30:1), Lemuel (31:1), and “the wise” (22:17; 24:23).

Some of the sayings in Proverbs show influence from neighboring cultures. For example, the “thirty sayings” of the wise (22:17–24:22) seems to borrow heavily from an Egyptian text called *The Instruction of Amenemope* (written around 1100 BC). The book of Proverbs reached its final form several centuries after the time of Solomon, as later teachers and editors added and arranged its material.

Readers

Proverbs 1:8–9:18 contains a series of messages from a father to a son. Some scholars debate whether the son was the writer’s actual son or a student being trained by him. This question arises because the Egyptian text *The Instruction of Amenemope* was addressed to a student. However, the references to a mother in Proverbs (for example, 1:8) suggest that the son was a biological child.

Much of Proverbs speaks directly to young men. For example, it includes warnings about sexual temptation and immoral relationships. However, the book is intended for a much wider audience. Its purpose is to teach wisdom to all people (1:2). This includes including both the inexperienced (1:4) and the wise (1:5). Proverbs is offered to everyone, but not everyone will choose to accept its teaching (1:7).

Meaning and Message

Proverbs is a book of practical wisdom for everyday life. It often presents wisdom as a father teaching his son. As the son moves through life, he faces important choices and must decide which path to follow.

The book of Proverbs helps people make wise choices. It teaches that wise actions often lead to good results, while foolish actions often lead to harmful results. These outcomes encourage people to follow wisdom, but they are not guaranteed in every situation.

Proverbs presents principles that are generally true, not promises that always come true. For example, a person who works hard and acts with integrity is likely to have more resources than a person who is lazy and unreliable. However, a lazy person may inherit wealth, and a hardworking person may lose wealth because of injustice or corruption. (This difference between righteous living and material reward is an important theme in the books of Job and Ecclesiastes.)

The advice in Proverbs can sometimes seem contradictory. However, careful reading and wisdom help readers understand when each saying applies. For example, should we answer a fool’s argument, or should we remain silent when someone refuses to listen? Proverbs 26:4–5 presents both possibilities. The right response depends on the situation.

We see the same pattern in many traditional sayings. One saying encourages caution, while another encourages quick action. Both can be true, depending on the circumstances. A wise person knows when a particular proverb applies and when it does not.

The wisdom in Proverbs is practical, but it is more than good advice. True wisdom comes from a reverent and trusting relationship with God, who is the source of all wisdom. This truth is expressed in Proverbs 1:7: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge.”

Proverbs calls us to make a spiritual choice. It teaches that true wisdom cannot be separated from a living relationship with God.